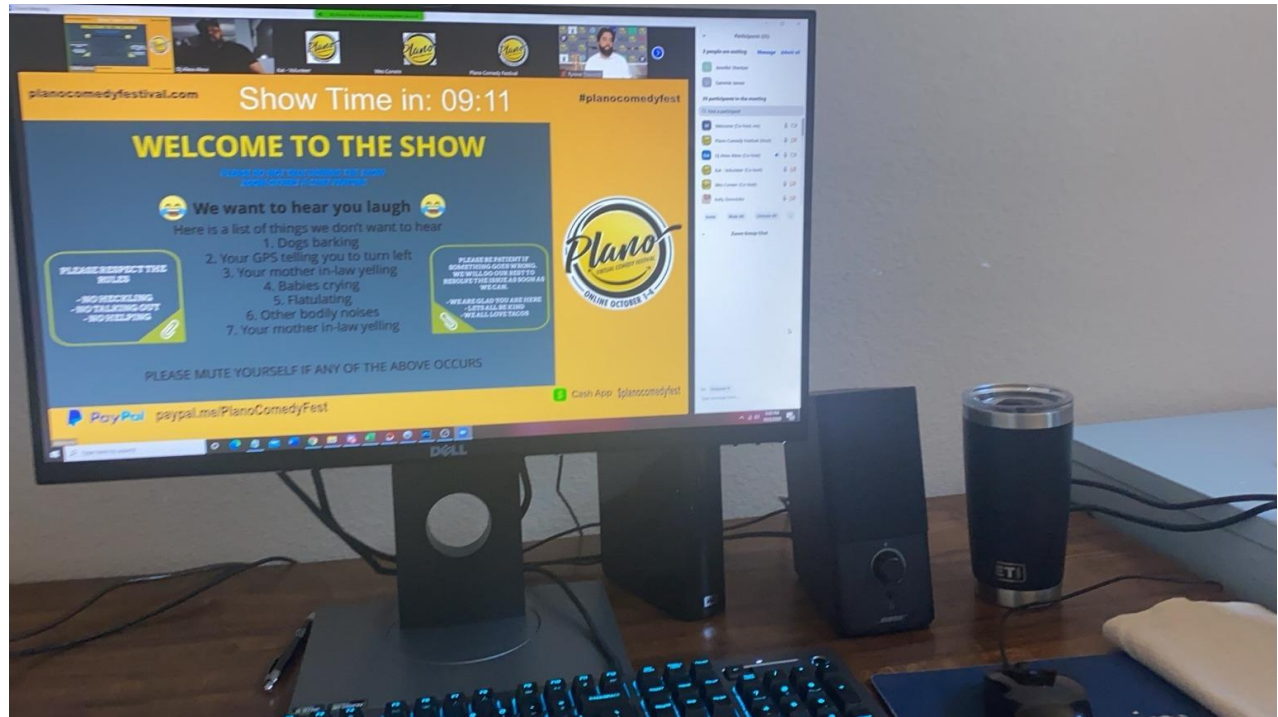


THE FESTIVAL THAT ALMOST DIDN'T HAPPEN

How three producers, 130 comedy submissions, a pile of unfamiliar technology, and one very important energy drink helped keep a comedy festival alive during COVID



Behind the scenes of the Plano Virtual Comedy Festival, October 1-4, 2020.

THOMAS SMITH | BOARD MEMBER / PRODUCER

On June 30, 2020, we made a decision we weren't entirely sure we could pull off.

The Plano Comedy Festival was going virtual.

I'm not going to pretend we immediately knew that was the right decision. We didn't.

For a while, we seriously considered canceling.

Stand-up comedy is about being in a room with people. A comedian stands onstage and immediately knows whether something worked. You can hear the laughter. You can feel the energy change. You can look at people's faces.

Now we were talking about replacing all of that with little boxes on a computer screen.

Comedian Steve Hofstetter was already doing virtual comedy shows, so we knew virtual stand-up *could* work. But there was a pretty big difference between putting on one virtual comedy show and producing an entire four-day comedy festival with more than 100 performers.

How were we going to depend on that many people's internet connections?

Could comedians perform without a real audience in front of them?

Could we make it interesting enough that the general public would actually buy tickets and sit in front of their computers to watch?

And, maybe most importantly:

Could we actually pull this thing off?

We decided there was only one way to find out.

Three people and a ridiculous idea



Show promotion became part of the production workload.



Virtual performer badges gave comics shareable promotional material.

Plano Comedy Festival is a nonprofit 501(c)(3), and our core production team consisted of three people: founder and president **Wes Corwin**, **Britanny Goss**, and me, **Thomas Smith**, a board member and producer.

We each had different responsibilities.

We managed the website, communicated back and forth with comedians, created montage videos, handled some of the social media and, as founder and president, made the final decisions.

Britainy handled much of the external side of the festival—venues, sponsors, City of Plano grant meetings, contacting agents for headlining comedians, and even getting the festival T-shirts produced and distributed.

My work leaned heavily toward the creative, technical and operational side: website QA, social media, performer selection, graphics, virtual badges, show posters, technology testing and eventually helping operate the virtual production itself.

But with three people producing a festival, job descriptions only get you so far.

When something needed to be done, somebody did it.

And none of us were being paid for the months of work we were about to put into this.

First, we needed comedians

Submissions opened July 1.

Because of the financial uncertainty surrounding COVID, we reduced the early submission fee to \$10. And if someone genuinely couldn't afford the fee, we created a limited number of sponsored submissions where a festival board member would cover it.

We wanted comedians to have an opportunity to participate regardless of what was happening financially.

Not everyone agreed with what we were doing.

I remember getting into an argument on Facebook with another comedian who accused us of taking advantage of comics during a terrible time.

I understood why people were skeptical. Comedy clubs were closed. Performers had lost work. Nobody knew when any of this was going to end.

But from where we sat, this wasn't some COVID money grab.

We were a nonprofit. We weren't getting paid.

We were trying to give comedians somewhere to perform when there was almost nowhere left to perform.

And apparently comedians were looking for exactly that.

We received 130 submissions.

Then came the fun part.

We had to watch them.

All of them.

The three of us reviewed the submission videos and selected the festival performers. Once we'd made those decisions, we had to turn more than 100 comedians into actual lineups across four days of programming.

And this wasn't going to be 17 identical Zoom comedy shows.

We tried to build an actual festival



Musical comedy required its own sound checks.



Sketch and alternative comedy expanded the festival beyond stand-up.

From October 1 through October 4, we scheduled **17 shows**, plus **two virtual workshops** and **two virtual after-parties**.

There were traditional showcases, late-night blue shows, a free family show, musical comedy, sketch and alternative comedy, brunch comedy, headliner shows and our closing roast battle.

Every show had a host.

Our headliners included **Laurie Kilmartin, Mary Kennedy, Roxxy Haze, Karith Foster, Steve Hofstetter** and **Kurt Braunohler**.

The workshops were free for comedians.

We even had a live DJ, **DJ Alexx from Waxahachie, Texas**, for every show.

Performers had walk-on music. Some selected their own songs; for others, DJ Alexx made the choice.

We had festival T-shirts.

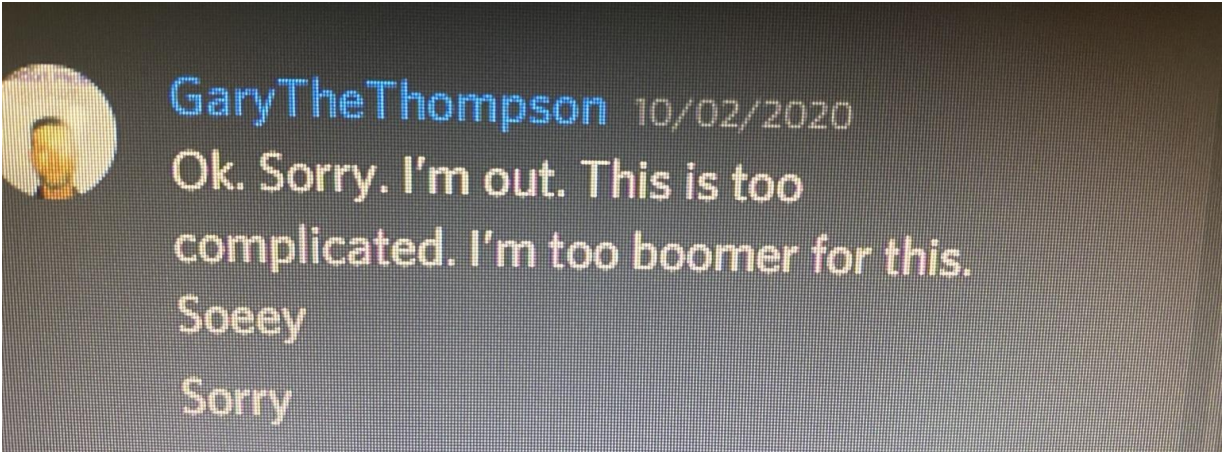
We had performer badges.

We had sponsors.

The venue disappeared.

The festival didn't.

Building a virtual comedy club



The audience waiting-room experience combined instructions, branding and sponsor visibility.

Once the comedians were selected, there was an enormous amount of work between *having a lineup* and *having a show*.

We collected bios, headshots and social-media information.

I created virtual performer badges containing the comedian's headshot, name, show date and time so they had something they could use to promote their appearance.

I created show graphics for Eventbrite and social media. We created promotional videos and ran a social-media campaign.

I also created branded Zoom backgrounds for performers and audience members. Some looked like virtual comedy stages with a stool and microphone. Others incorporated festival and sponsor branding.

But graphics were the easy part.

We had to figure out how to recreate the mechanics of an actual comedy venue.

Eventually our virtual workflow started looking something like this:

Eventbrite became the box office.

Zoom became the venue and stage.

The Zoom waiting area became the lobby.

Discord became the green room.

Comedians could communicate with producers through Discord, know when they were coming up, and prepare to move into the live show.

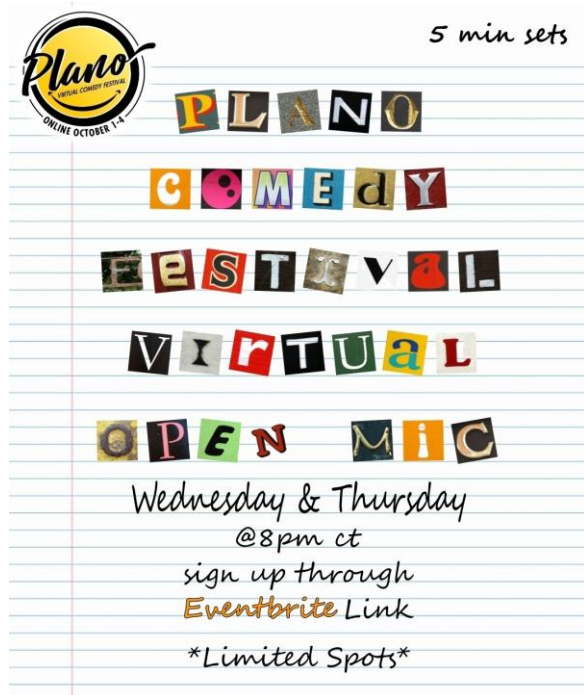
We recruited volunteers to help check audience members in from the virtual waiting area and manage the shows. If somebody had loud background noise, volunteers could mute them before their television, dog or family member unexpectedly became part of the act.

We even created an **audience education video** that ran while people were waiting to enter the show.

Because in 2020, we weren't only teaching comedians how to perform virtually.

We were teaching audiences how to attend virtually.

Teaching comedians how to perform to a computer



Weekly virtual open mics helped performers practice the format.



A branded Zoom environment helped the festival feel like a shared venue.

One problem we couldn't completely solve was laughter.

Performing stand-up over Zoom is weird.

In a small comedy room, silence tells you something. Usually something you don't want to hear.

On Zoom, silence didn't necessarily mean the joke bombed.

People could be muted. Their microphones might not pick up their laughter. Reactions arrived differently. The comedian couldn't feel the room the same way.

So before the festival, we started running weekly virtual open mics.

Those open mics became more than technical tests. They gave performers an opportunity to experience what virtual stand-up actually felt like.

We could also provide recommendations about lighting, cameras, sound and backgrounds.

Some people needed more help than others.

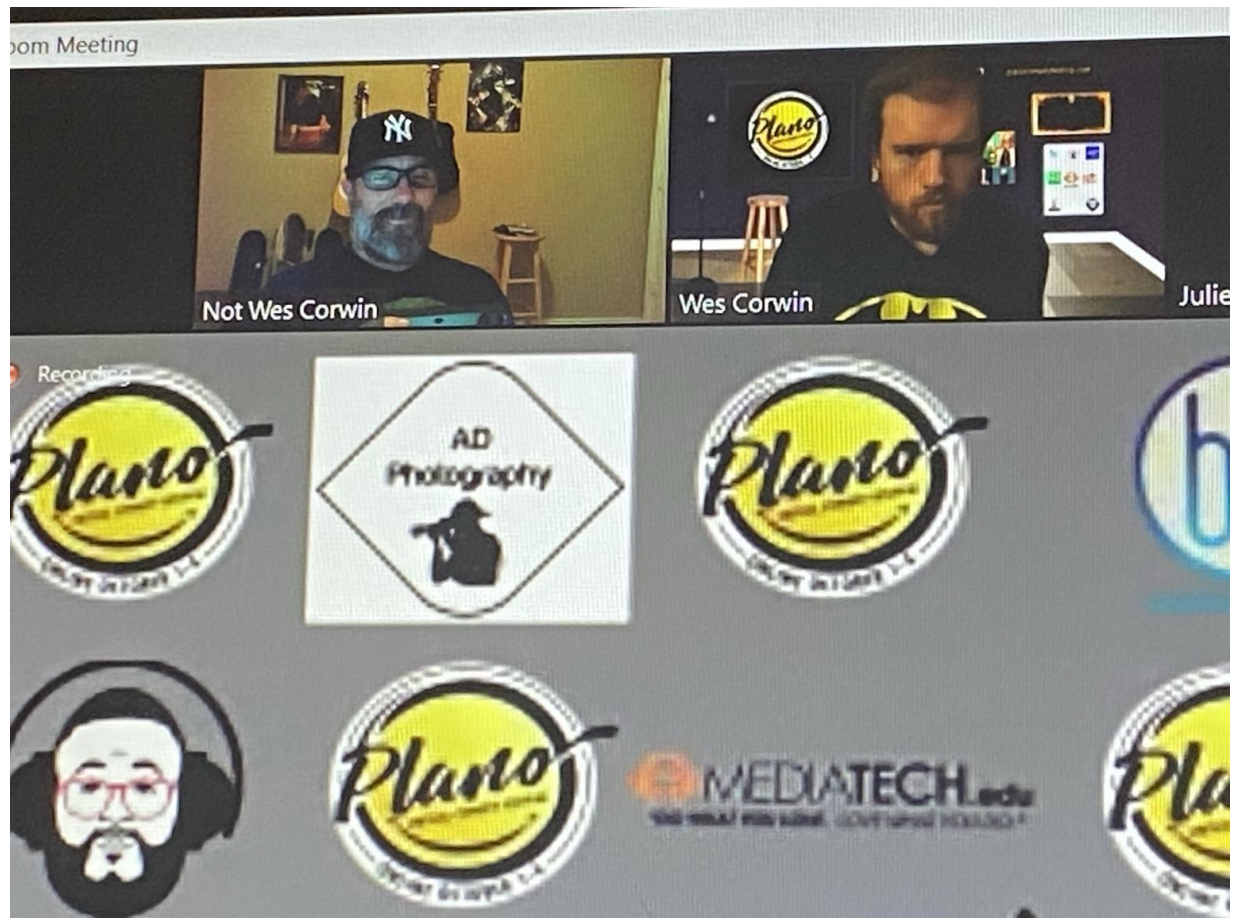
We later jokingly gave out unofficial distinctions for things like worst lighting, worst internet connection, missing in action and the best "Boomer moment."

One comedian's connection was so bad that we joked that we thought he'd been eaten by bears.

Another performer missed his spot entirely and texted about **three hours later** asking if he could still go up.

Virtual comedy was a learning experience for everybody.

Then OBS showed up



The home production setup used to run the festival.

OBS wasn't part of some beautifully designed six-month technical plan.

It was basically:

We have a problem. We need to solve it.

We had created a branded pre-show presentation that would loop while the audience arrived. It promoted shows, performers and sponsors and helped make the experience feel like an event rather than a random Zoom meeting.

But then we realized:

How do we smoothly get from that into the live show?

We needed to transition from the pre-show presentation to the host and then spotlight the comedians as they performed.

OBS became the solution.

Which meant I had to learn OBS.

Quickly.

We tested pieces of the system, held meetings with hosts, tested technology and ran the open mics.

What we did **not** do was a complete end-to-end production rehearsal.

So after months of work, we basically trusted what we'd built and went live.

And amazingly...

it worked.

The slideshow ended.

The host appeared.

The comedians performed.

The transitions worked.

The audience was there.

We had actually built a virtual comedy festival.

There was just one small problem.

We forgot to hit Record



The festival live inside Zoom.



Audience members joined the shows from home.

I can't tell you much about our very first show.

I don't remember it.

And unfortunately, neither can anybody who wasn't there.

From the beginning, we'd been adamant that we were going to record every comedian's performance.

Then we got so focused on successfully launching the festival that **we forgot to record the first show.**

We didn't realize it until a few minutes into Show #2.

After that, recording suddenly became a very important part of the process.

Every remaining show was captured.

So the first show of the 2020 Plano Virtual Comedy Festival basically exists only in the memories of the people who attended it.

Which feels strangely appropriate for 2020.

Seventeen shows means seventeen opportunities for something to go wrong



Performers appeared from separate rooms and internet connections.



Live chat and audience interaction became part of the atmosphere.

And things did.

People's internet connections failed.

Lighting was terrible.

People couldn't figure out Zoom.

Comedians missed their spots.

Audience members needed to be muted.

Performers had to be moved through the virtual green room and into the show.

Hosts needed to know who was next.

We had to transition between performers while maintaining the rhythm of an actual comedy show.

Some of the programming presented completely different technical problems.

Saturday afternoon, for example, we produced a **musical comedy show**.

Now we weren't just dealing with voices over Zoom. Comedians were playing instruments.

We conducted sound checks.

And somehow, **it worked perfectly**.

Sunday's sketch and alternative comedy show included groups with as many as eight performers.

And all weekend, DJ Alexx provided music and helped create the feeling that something was happening between sets rather than everybody simply staring at another Zoom window.

Saturday nearly broke me



A personal moment from an exhausting festival Saturday.

The months leading up to the festival were incredibly challenging.

The festival weekend itself was something else entirely.

I could be stuck in that room for as long as **12 hours in a day**.

And yes, after enough hours...

the room smelled bad.

By Saturday, I was physically and mentally exhausted.

There were comedians to manage, audience problems, internet problems and production issues. You're constantly watching for whatever might go wrong next because the audience doesn't care what's happening behind the curtain.

At one point Saturday, I was done.

Not *"I'm getting tired."*

Done.

My wife showed up with an energy drink.

I joke that she literally saved my life that afternoon, but at that particular moment it didn't feel like much of an exaggeration.

I drank it.

And kept going.

But exhaustion wasn't the hardest thing we were dealing with that weekend.

Our family had received devastating news that my brother-in-law and his wife had lost their baby.

And I still had to perform.

I had two shows of my own and the roast battle to host.

There's an old saying in entertainment:

The show must go on.

That weekend I understood it differently.

People watching our festival had problems of their own. It was 2020. People were isolated. People were scared. People were grieving. Everybody was dealing with something.

For a little while, they had decided to spend their time with us.

They wanted an escape.

And that's what we were going to give them.

So when the camera came on, you put the smile on your face.

And you performed.

The chef's kiss



The Roast Battle bracket that closed the festival.



Thomas Smith - ring announcer.



Wes Corwin - ring announcer.

By Sunday night, we'd almost made it.

There was one show left.

The Roast Battle.

Seventeen performers.

The roast battle closes the festival, and Wes and I love it.

After months of unpaid work...

After 130 submission videos...

After weekly Zoom meetings...

After schedules, badges, posters and social-media campaigns...

After Eventbrite, Discord, Zoom, OBS and Powtoon...

After terrible lighting, disappearing comedians, bad internet and the first show we forgot to record...

After 12-hour days...

After everything...

we got to the roast battle.

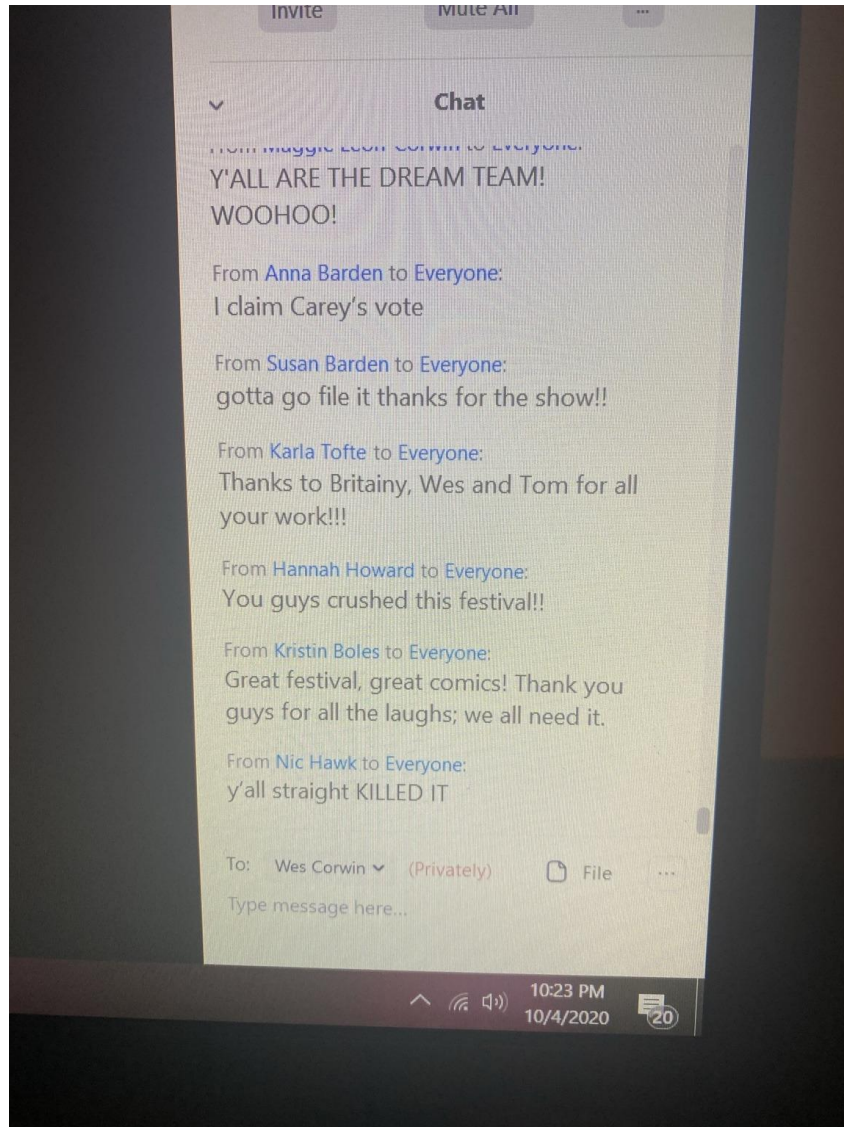
That's why Wes and I endure the months of painstaking work that go into producing the festival.

Not for money.

For that moment.

It's the chef's kiss.

What I remember six years later



One of the surviving glimpses of the audience and performer experience.

When we announced the virtual festival on June 30, we weren't sure it would work.

We weren't even sure people wanted it to work.

But more than 100 comedians eventually performed. Audiences showed up. We produced showcases, headliner shows, workshops, after-parties, musical comedy, sketch comedy, family programming and a roast battle across four days.

And we gave comedians somewhere to perform during a time when stages across the country were dark.

There's one part of the story I especially appreciate looking back.

Comedian **Al Coseglia** continued with virtual comedy after that period and today hosts a weekly online open mic for older performers called *Ye Olde Mic*.

I wouldn't claim our festival created that.

But I think it represents something we couldn't have known when we were sitting in those Zoom production meetings wondering whether virtual comedy could work.

We thought we were building a temporary bridge until comedy clubs reopened.

For some comedians, the bridge led somewhere new.

And maybe that's what I'm proudest of when I think about the Plano Virtual Comedy Festival.

We didn't invent virtual comedy.

We didn't solve every problem.

Hell, **we didn't even remember to record the first show.**

But during one of the strangest and most difficult periods any of us had experienced, three producers, a group of volunteers, a DJ, more than 100 comedians and a whole bunch of technology we'd figured out along the way managed to create something that gave people a reason to laugh.

And for four days in October 2020...

the show went on.